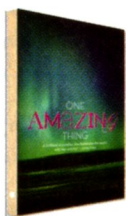


Mush and MEMORY

A visa office of an Indian consulate is the new venue for diasporic sentimentalism



ONE AMAZING THING

by CHITRA BANERJEE
DIVAKARUNI
Hamish Hamilton
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By Brinda Bose

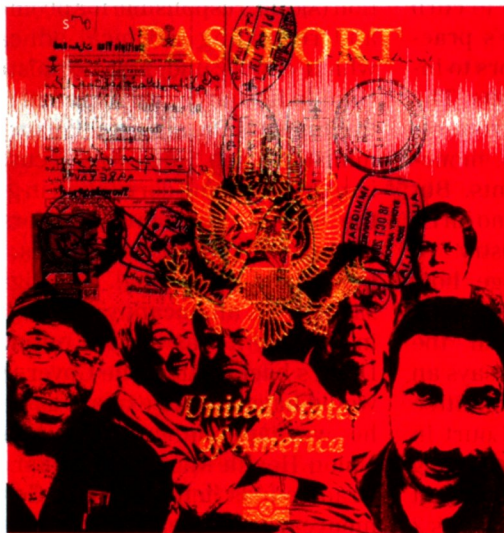
"I started writing," said Indian-American writer Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni some years ago, "as an action to prevent myself from forgetting. It was a very personal thing." Her latest novel, *One Amazing Thing*, enacts this very adumbration in its structure of digging into remembrances of things past even as one sits threatened by the rubble of the present collapsing all around. Its most significant contribution to fictions of forgetting and remembering may well be this: that an exercise to recollect, while in a state of distress, one amazing thing about one's chequered past is a canny tool to finally counteract numerous free-floating signifiers that all add up to sound and fury—and nothing.

Memory in Divakaruni, as with many other diasporic writers, is always viscerally linked to the culture of the original homeland, and most of her 11 novels explore facets of South Asian immigrant experience in North America with a finger dipped in nostalgia. After spending the first 19 years of her life in Calcutta, Divakaruni left for America for graduate studies and settled there after a doctoral degree from Berkeley, teaching creative writing and literature at the University of Houston and prolifically producing novels, short story collections, poetry and children's fiction. Her anthology of stories, *Arranged Marriage*, won the American Book Award in 1995, while *Mistress of Spices*, arguably her best-known work, was shortlisted for the Orange Prize in 1997 and was later turned into a film by Gurinder Chadha and Paul Mayeda Berges in 2005, starring Aishwarya Rai.

Divakaruni probes the inherent immigrant yearning for an assimilated lifestyle that can enjoy paranthas with pasta in ultimate-pot-pourri-land. She reminds one of Bharati

Mukherjee, with whom she shares some uncanny marks of resemblance, not least their shared heritage of (the same) girls' convent-school education in Calcutta and a flight westwards to the land of plenty, to study, marry, teach and write.

Her latest, however, seeks to retrieve the common song of schmaltzy diasporic sentimentality from its tiredness, and cast it afresh in a narrative framework that makes reminiscence its very raison d'être—indeed, the device by which the terror of death is stayed, almost in the tradition of Scheherazade. *One Amazing Thing* mounts an intricate tapestry of nine stories told by nine characters trapped in the visa office of an Indian Consulate in an unnamed American city when the building collapses in an earthquake. As they await rescue—or death—huddling together in a blitzed-out room where parts of the ceiling continue to cave in, and the floodwaters are rising even as the corridors are cut off by heaps of fallen debris, they tell each other of one amazing thing that they each recall from their lives. The nine represent the diversity of the country they all call home: as Cameron, a taciturn African-American war veteran, provides leadership in pursuing practical survival, a young graduate student haunted by a question about love suggests life-story-telling as psychological warfare against fear; the others—an older upper-class white couple whose relationship is teetering, a punky teenager with an unusual gift, a Chinese grandmother with a shrouded past, a young Muslim man struggling to come to terms with 9/11 and two visa officers on the verge of an adulterous affair—respond with their single-most-amazing experiences of family, romance, marriage, politics and self-discovery. Time passes. She offers us a touching fable for our frenetic times, in which we can save each other—and ourselves, our souls—by remembering, rather than forgetting. ■



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